CYBERCAB FLEET OWNERS · PUBLIC EDITION

The Economics of a Cybercab

What every kilometre costs an owner , and which assumptions move it most

Version 1.0 · Oct 31, 2026

Written by the expert team of the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community , based on the analysis of Cern Basher

cybercabfleetowners.com

Independent community, not affiliated with Tesla, Inc.

Contents

Version 1.0 · Oct 31, 2026

- Chapter 1 : From wage to machine
- Chapter 2 : Buying and financing the car
- Chapter 3 : The cost per kilometre , line by line
- Chapter 4 : Utilisation and empty kilometres
- Chapter 5 : The levers Tesla controls
- Chapter 6 : Sensitivity : which assumptions matter most
- Chapter 7 : Risks and what to watch
- Chapter 8 : Growing a fleet from one car

Where this comes from

This guide is built on the interview If You Buy a CYBERCAB How Much MONEY Could You Make ? on Brighter with Herbert (Herbert Ong , 21 Feb 2026 , 1 h 12 min) , https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wftOjQgleu0 , with analyst Cern Basher , and on his X article If you Purchase a Cybercab how Much Money can you Make ? (18 Feb 2026) https://x.com/CernBasher/status/2024241623883034965 and his follow-up post Tesla Robotaxi Take Rate : What's Optimal ? (19 Feb 2026) https://x.com/CernBasher/status/2024510824132297154 , and his X article Building Your Cybercab Fleet (9 Mar 2026) https://x.com/CernBasher/status/2030979224819900515 . All model figures are his assumptions and estimates , paraphrased .

Before you read

Not financial advice . Tesla has not published owner terms , prices or fees . This edition contains no earnings , return , revenue , fee or price figures .

CHAPTER 1

From wage to machine

Why the car becomes an asset

An Uber driver trades hours for money . An Airbnb host deals with guests and cleaning at odd hours . A Cybercab owner , in Cern Basher's framing , does neither : the car joins a network and works while the owner sleeps . That idea is attractive , and that is exactly why the costs deserve a careful look .

What this chapter covers
Why Tesla might sell cars to owners at all · The shift from labour to capital · The one metric to watch

This chapter covers why owner cars may exist , what changes when a car becomes a productive asset , and why cost per kilometre is the number to watch .

Proof point 1 : peaks and troughs
Ride demand peaks in the morning and evening · A fleet sized for peaks sits idle overnight

Ride demand has sharp peaks and deep night-time troughs , as New Street Research data shown in the video illustrates . Basher argues Tesla can run a base fleet around the clock and let owner cars add capacity at the peaks , which lowers how much capital Tesla itself must tie up .

Proof point 2 : capital and allies
Selling cars recycles capital · Many owners spread the benefit , and the political support

Selling cars lets Tesla recycle capital and run factories at full capacity . Spreading ownership also creates many owners with a stake in the network , which Basher sees as protection against political pressure .

Proof point 3 : home charging and placement
Distributed home charging eases Supercharger load · Cars start the day spread across the city

Cars that charge at owners' homes reduce the need for new chargers , and they start the morning spread through the city instead of queuing out of one depot .

Cost per km

The one metric in this guide · measured over all kilometres , paid and empty

Wider than robotaxis
Like a rental property , but the asset wears out · The same logic may reach vans , trucks and other

> robots

Basher compares it to the rental property market : for the first time a vehicle can be bought on its expected use . Unlike a building , the car wears out , so depreciation per kilometre is central to everything that follows .

> **Discuss this chapter**
> Bring your own numbers to the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community on X : https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

CHAPTER 2

Buying and financing the car

Purchase , loan and what a lender looks at

Two buyers order the same car . One pays cash , one borrows almost all of it . On day one their cars are identical . By year three their cost per kilometre is not , because financing is a cost line too .

> **What this chapter covers**
> The purchase and its likely conditions · Financing as a fixed yearly cost · How lenders may judge the asset

This chapter covers the purchase , how financing enters your cost per kilometre , and how a lender may look at a car that earns on a network .

> **Proof point 1 : conditions may come attached**
> Possible minimum network hours · Personal use may be priced differently

Basher expects Tesla to attach conditions to owner sales , for example a minimum number of hours in the network each month , because a car parked in a driveway does not help the network . Personal-only use may cost more in software fees .

> **Proof point 2 : financing is fixed , depreciation is not**
> Financing cost stays the same whatever you drive · Depreciation rises with kilometres driven

In his model financing is a fixed yearly cost , while the vehicle cost , depreciation , grows with mileage because a car that drives more reaches the end of its battery life sooner . He assumes a battery life of about 600,000 miles (about 965,000 km) , on the careful side .

> **Proof point 3 : the lender's view**
> Credit may follow the asset , not only the borrower · Asset-backed markets already exist

He suggests lenders may judge the car's network income more than the borrower's salary , as with asset-backed securities . Until owner terms exist , expect lenders to ask for your own careful case .

> **Deep dive : depreciation depends on funding**
> The largest cost line · Cash · loan · lease · pooled fleet · Residual-value risk sits with different parties

The same expert business plan puts depreciation ahead of every running cost , and notes that its size depends on the funding structure . A buyer with a loan carries the full loss of value plus interest ; a

lease or pooled fleet moves part of the residual-value risk to someone else , at a price . Choose the funding route before fixing your cost per kilometre .

> **The funding plan solution**
> Write off over 8 to 10 years , not a 4-year lease · Fund the self-driving part separately · Fund on cash flows , not residual value · Keep the purchase cost low

Michiel van Duijn presented the expert team's solution in Robotaxi Countdown episode 39 (youtube.com/watch?v=2GpLG7RqqTk) : spread the write-off over the car's real life , fund the self-driving part with investors who share its upside , and fund robotaxis on future cash flows with asset-based interest plus a share of ride income , so the car repays its own loan . A used car is never worth more than a new one , so a low purchase price matters too . See our separate Funding and Depreciation guide .

> **Discuss this chapter**
> Bring your own numbers to the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community on X : https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

CHAPTER 3

The cost per kilometre , line by line

Energy , insurance , cleaning , maintenance , depreciation , platform share

Ask a new owner what the car costs and they name the loan payment . Ask again after a year and they name tyres , insurance and the electricity bill . The cost per kilometre is all of those lines , divided by every kilometre the car drives .

What this chapter covers
The ten cost lines in Basher's model · Fixed versus variable costs · His cost per km range

This chapter covers each cost line , which ones are fixed and which grow with use , and the cost per kilometre that comes out .

Cost line	How Basher models it	Type
Energy (charging)	Home charging at about $0.16 per kWh in the base case , about $0.35 when using fast chargers	Variable
Insurance	Physical damage paid by the owner ; he expects Tesla to carry liability	Fixed
Cleaning	Zero in the base case (owner cleans) ; paid if Tesla or a provider does it	Variable
Tyres and maintenance	Rises with kilometres , one of the biggest variable lines	Variable
Depreciation (vehicle cost)	Purchase spread over battery life	Variable
Financing	Interest on the loan	Fixed
Autonomy software	Monthly FSD subscription	Fixed
Parking	Zero on a private driveway , paid in cities	Fixed
Taxes and other	EV road taxes and fees , differ by state or country	Fixed
Platform share	Tesla's share of every fare	% of fares

Proof point 1 : tyres are a big line
Heavy daily mileage wears tyres fast · A slow , city-only design may help

Tyres and maintenance are among the largest lines . The Cybercab is built for city speeds with gentle acceleration and cornering , which may reduce wear , but daily inspections will still be needed .

Proof point 2 : insurance splits in two
Liability : expected with Tesla · Physical damage : with the owner

He expects Tesla to take the liability side , leaving the owner to insure damage to the car itself . That is an assumption until owner terms are published .

$0.23 to $0.32 per mile

Basher's modelled cost over all miles , paid and empty · about $0.14 to $0.20 per km · falling as utilisation rises

Proof point 3 : cost per km falls with use
Fixed costs spread over more kilometres · Variable costs stay roughly flat per kilometre

His modelled cost falls from about 20 to 14 US cents per kilometre as the car moves from 30% to 65% utilisation , because fixed lines are spread over more kilometres . These are his estimates , in US conditions , and exclude the platform share .

Wider than the car
Parking , cleaning and marketing were set near zero · For a small fleet , add them back

His base case sets parking , cleaning and marketing close to zero for a home owner . A fleet with a depot , paid cleaning and its own staff must add these lines back , which is why chapter 6 of our implementation guide builds careful , middle and hopeful cases .

A second view : ten cost drivers per mile , by AJ (@alojoh)

Cost driver	Key inputs	¢ per mile	¢ per km	Share
Depreciation	Vehicle $21K · 4-year life · 313K mi total	7.2	4.5	45.5 %
Cleaning	Every 345 mi · $11.4 per clean	3.3	2.1	20.7 %
Electricity	18 kWh per 100 mi · 13.2 ¢ per kWh	2.4	1.5	15.0 %
Interior refurbishment	$815 per 80K mi	1.0	0.6	6.4 %
Tires and wheels	$255 per 30K mi	0.8	0.5	5.3 %
Insurance equivalent	$204 a year per 15K mi , 50% discount	0.6	0.4	3.6 %
Wipers	$15 per 10K mi	0.2	0.1	1.0 %
Brakes	$102 per 80K mi (regenerative braking)	0.1	0.1	0.8 %
Air filter and AC	$36 per 40K mi	0.1	0.1	0.5 %
All other	$51 per 30K mi	0.2	0.1	1.1 %
Total	**Forecast for Q1 2027**	**15.9**	**9.9**	**100 %**

Notes from the source : cost per mile is per mile driven , meaning total miles including empty miles , not paid miles · the forecast includes 2.5 % yearly inflation · vehicle cost , cleaning and electricity together make up more than 80 % of the cost per mile . Kilometre values converted by us (÷ 1.609) . Source : AJ (@alojoh) , Tesla Ride Hailing Cost Drivers , Part 1 , Cost per Mile Driven , based on company filings , 8 May 2025 . Figures are his estimates for a Tesla-operated fleet , in US dollars .

Deep dive : cleaning and charging
Cleaning ≈ 20% of operating cost per km · Charging ≈ 15% · Together ≈ 35% , the biggest running costs after depreciation

An expert business plan for operating and funding a Cybercab fleet reaches a different conclusion from the video on one point : cleaning is not close to zero . It estimates cleaning at about 20 percent and charging at about 15 percent of total operating cost per kilometre , together about 35 percent , making them the largest running costs after depreciation . With no driver to tidy up , cleaning frequency , labour

and depot set-up decide this line , and shared depots and crews lower both . Never model cleaning at zero .

> **Discuss this chapter**
> Bring your own numbers to the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community on X :
> https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

CHAPTER 4

Utilisation and empty kilometres

How busy the car is decides almost everything

Two identical cars sit in the same city . One drives seven hours a day , the other fifteen . Their costs per year differ by less than you think . Their costs per kilometre differ a lot .

What this chapter covers
What utilisation means · Empty kilometres · Rural versus city

This chapter covers what utilisation means in practice , how empty kilometres raise your cost , and how the picture changes outside the city .

Proof point 1 : utilisation is time with a rider
30% = about 7.2 hours a day in service · 65% = about 15.6 hours a day

Basher defines utilisation as time actually in service , not time available . A car can be on the network all day and still reach only 30% on a slow day . At 30% he estimates about 18 to 19 trips and 157 miles (about 250 km) a day , within one home charge .

Proof point 2 : empty kilometres
Base case : 40% of all miles are empty · Rural case : 100% , every trip returns empty

He assumes 40% of all miles carry no rider , repositioning and driving to pick-ups , higher than the 35% estimate cited in our implementation guide . In his rural case every trip returns empty . Each empty kilometre still costs energy , tyres and depreciation .

Proof point 3 : dwell time
About 3 minutes to load and unload · Waiting riders may be charged per minute

Loading and unloading take about three minutes per trip in his model . He suggests charging riders who stay in the car , for example during a call , as if it were still driving .

40%

Share of all miles that are empty in Basher's base case · his assumption

Wider than one car
Revenue pooling by area may reduce placement luck

He raises the idea that owners might share in the earnings of their area , so a car parked in the wrong place on a quiet night is not penalised . Tesla has not said how it will work .

> **Discuss this chapter**
> Bring your own numbers to the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community on X :
> https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

CHAPTER 5

The levers Tesla controls

Car price , software fee and platform share

Imagine you run pricing at Tesla . You can change three dials : what the car costs , what the software costs each month and what share of every fare you keep . Turn one up and you can turn another down . Every owner's cost per kilometre depends on where those dials end up .

What this chapter covers
The three dials · Dynamic pricing · What fairness between Tesla and owners means

This chapter covers the three levers Tesla controls , why fares will likely be dynamic , and how Basher tests whether a split is fair to both sides .

Proof point 1 : Tesla is hiring for dynamic pricing
A robotaxi pricing role · Surge pricing , taxes , tolls , regional factors

A Tesla job posting for robotaxi pricing describes models for dynamic and surge pricing that include base cost , taxes , fees , tolls , demand and location . Pricing balances supply and demand , which keeps wait times short .

Proof point 2 : the dials trade off
Lower software fee , higher platform share · Or the other way round

Basher shows Tesla could give the software away and keep a larger share of fares , or charge a high monthly fee and keep a smaller share , and land in a similar place . Volume discounts for owners with several cars are another possible lever .

Proof point 3 : the fairness test
Compare owner and Tesla gross profit per car · A split that is far off either way is unlikely to last

In his take-rate post he compares what the owner and Tesla each keep per car . His view : the split that looks fair to both sides sits in a fairly narrow band , and it shifts with fare levels and software fees .

3 dials

Car price · software fee · platform share · all unknown until Tesla publishes owner terms

Wider than Tesla
Today's rideshare prices are far above the costs Tesla targets

Tesla's stated targets of roughly 25 to 30 US cents per mile are costs , not prices , as the video stresses . Fares will be set by the market , competition and regulation .

> **Discuss this chapter**
> Bring your own numbers to the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community on X :
> https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

CHAPTER 6

Sensitivity : which assumptions matter most

Run your careful , middle and hopeful case

Every model gives the answer its assumptions allow . Basher says so himself : it is easy to get a desired outcome by tweaking a few inputs . The useful question is not what the answer is , but which inputs move it most .

What this chapter covers
The inputs that move the result · What to test first · How to use this with the implementation guide

This chapter covers which assumptions matter most , in what order to test them , and how to put them into your own cost sheet .

Assumption	Base case	Tested	Effect on owner costs or margin
Utilisation	30% to 65%	30% to 65%	Biggest single driver ; cost per km falls as fixed costs spread
Empty kilometres	40%	Up to 100% (rural)	More empty km , more cost per paid km
Energy price	Home charging	Fast charging	Higher energy line , modest overall effect
Software fee	Monthly subscription	Free to high	Can wipe out the owner margin at a high platform share
Platform share	Mid-range	Low to half of fares	Very large effect on what remains for costs
Battery life	600,000 miles	Up to 1 million	Longer life lowers depreciation per km
Fare level	Low , Austin-style	Up to double	Strongest effect on viability ; not shown in this edition

Proof point 1 : utilisation first
Fixed costs are about half the yearly total · Low use means high cost per km

Because financing , insurance , software and taxes are largely fixed , a quiet car carries a high cost per kilometre .

Proof point 2 : software fee and platform share together
Test them as a pair

In his take-rate post a high software fee combined with a high platform share leaves the owner with nothing to cover costs . Always test the two together .

> **Proof point 3 : local costs**
> Energy , taxes , parking and insurance vary by place

His model uses US home-owner costs . European or other local energy , insurance , parking and road taxes can be very different , so replace each line with a local quote .

Careful case first

Low utilisation · high empty share · paid cleaning and parking · fast charging

> **Wider than the model**
> Extra revenue layers were left out on purpose

He modelled trips only , leaving out delivery , advertising and in-car services . They may come , but plan without them .

> **Discuss this chapter**
> Bring your own numbers to the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community on X :
> https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

CHAPTER 7

Risks and what to watch

What could change the numbers

The first owners will buy before anyone has real data . That is the opportunity and the risk in one sentence .

> **What this chapter covers**
> The main risks · The signals to watch · Where to discuss them

This chapter lists the risks that matter most for cost per kilometre and the signals that will tell you whether the assumptions hold .

> **Risk 1 : owner terms**
> Platform share , software fee , minimum hours · Insurance split , pooling rules

Nothing in this guide is confirmed by Tesla . Owner terms decide most cost lines .

> **Risk 2 : utilisation and placement**
> Tesla's own base fleet may take the busiest hours · Owner cars may serve peaks only

If owner cars mainly cover peaks , utilisation may be lower than in a car that runs all day . Watch how dispatch treats owner cars .

> **Risk 3 : wear , regulation and competition**
> Tyres , cleaning and damage from heavy use · Local permits , taxes and insurance rules · Falling fares as supply grows

Heavy use wears cars faster than private driving . Rules and taxes differ by city and country . As more cars join , fares may fall , and the early picture may not last .

> **Risk 4 : source bias**
> Model by one analyst · Optimistic framing in the video

The video and posts present one analyst's model in an enthusiastic interview . The host and guest disclose they hold Tesla shares . Treat the figures as a starting point , not evidence .

Signals to watch

Published owner terms · measured empty-km share of early fleets · real insurance quotes · local energy prices

What it means for your plan
Build the cost sheet now , fill in facts as they arrive · Not financial advice

Use the cost lines in this guide , add your local quotes and run a careful case before you order a car . This guide describes costs , not investments . Not financial advice .

Discuss this chapter
Bring your own numbers to the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community on X : https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

CHAPTER 8

Growing a fleet from one car

Reinvesting , and what slows it down

Someone with modest savings buys one car . Every month its spare cash goes into a pot , and whenever the pot covers a down payment another car is ordered . In Cern Basher's article Building Your Cybercab Fleet , that simple rule turns one car into a fleet within a few years . The idea is powerful . The limits are where the real work is .

What this chapter covers
How reinvestment compounds · Which inputs drive the speed · The constraints he lists himself

This chapter covers his reinvestment scenario , the inputs that make it fast or slow , and the real-world limits an owner must plan for .

Proof point 1 : slow , then fast
Year one : a handful of cars · Then growth accelerates

Growth starts slowly because only one car contributes . Each new car adds to the pot , so purchases speed up over time . He runs it on his individual-owner model including all expenses , at a low 30% utilisation , with a down payment per car and a bank loan for the rest .

Proof point 2 : one input changes everything
Fare level · utilisation · loan terms · Compounding magnifies small differences

Changing a single input , in his case the base fare , changes the outcome dramatically . The same compounding works against you : lower utilisation , higher insurance or higher energy prices slow growth just as strongly .

Proof point 3 : the constraints
Tesla's supply and willingness to sell · Parking , depots and local rules · Lender appetite

He warns not to take the projection to the bank . It assumes unlimited cars from Tesla and ignores where cars park , as he jokes , more than your homeowners' association allows .

Cost per km per car

The test for every next car · fleet costs such as depot , cleaning and staff appear as you grow

Wider than one owner

> The same logic drives pooled fleets · Staged growth on real data

The same reinvestment logic is how pooled fleets would grow . In practice , grow in stages and fund each next car only after earlier cars show real cost and use data . Not financial advice .

> **Discuss this chapter**
> Bring your own numbers to the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community on X :
> https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

JOIN US

Work out your own cost per kilometre with the community

Share your local energy , insurance and parking quotes with other future owners , and get every update of this guide first :

X community
https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

Website
cybercabfleetowners.com

Sources : the interview If You Buy a CYBERCAB How Much MONEY Could You Make ? on the YouTube channel Brighter with Herbert (@BrighterwithHerbert , host Herbert Ong , 21 Feb 2026) , https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wftOjQgleu0 ; Cern Basher (@CernBasher) , X article If you Purchase a Cybercab how Much Money can you Make ? (18 Feb 2026) , https://x.com/CernBasher/status/2024241623883034965 ; and his post Tesla Robotaxi Take Rate : What's Optimal ? (19 Feb 2026) , https://x.com/CernBasher/status/2024510824132297154 ; Cern Basher , X article Building Your Cybercab Fleet (9 Mar 2026) , https://x.com/CernBasher/status/2030979224819900515 . The cost driver table in chapter 3 rebuilds a slide by AJ (@alojoh) , Tesla Ride Hailing Cost Drivers (8 May 2025) , based on company filings . The funding plan solution in chapter 2 paraphrases Michiel van Duijn , Robotaxi Countdown episode 39 , youtube.com/watch?v=2GpLG7RqqTk . The deep dives on cleaning , charging and depreciation in chapters 2 and 3 draw on an expert business plan for operating and funding a Cybercab fleet , written by members of the expert team . All other model assumptions and estimates are theirs , paraphrased . Miles converted to kilometres by us . Not financial advice . Tesla has not published owner terms , prices or fees . This edition contains no earnings , return , revenue , fee or price figures . Independent community, not affiliated with Tesla, Inc.